
Hurry Slowly - The Jesuit Catalogs Database and Obstacles to Automation

David Thomas^{*1} and Alessandro Corsi^{*†}

¹Boston College (BC) – United States

Abstract

The Jesuit Catalogs Database project (<https://jesuitcatalogs.bc.edu/>) explores the biographical records of the census of every Jesuit community around the world, conducted consistently every three years for over three centuries, found in hundreds of linear meters of physical sources. This includes information about the Jesuit's health, studies, jobs, that allows scholars to identify each single member. It also includes economic records of communities and psychological assessments for human resource management. As shown by Díaz Blanco, Mariani, Kádár and Corsi, Jesuit catalogs represent one of the most complete pools of data for demographic studies in the Early Modern Period. When completed, this project will provide centuries of network data on hundreds of thousands of individuals.

While the potentials for network analysis abound, the size, variability, accessibility of the sources all pose daunting problems. At this volume, automated methods of data input seem attractive. But, Jesuits change names, communities change places, abbreviations change, and sources are written by different hands. The particular problems of disambiguation have made automation problematic at scale. Instead, we suggest that for our project, a custom application that enables collaboration on data entry solves the sticky problem of data control. We built a web platform primarily focused on complex data entry to enable the scholars constructing the dataset to be able to find and cross reference specific members and communities. The paper aims to show how creating systems for human-centered entry can produce higher-quality datasets, thereby providing a more reliable foundation for automated analysis.

While our sources urge a slow approach to the data input phase, we see a great deal of promise when it comes to querying. We plan to explore an MCP and Tool-augmented local LLM so that non-technical users, including scholars and students, can query network data using only plain language.

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^{*}Speaker

[†]Corresponding author: corsial@bc.edu

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